



PROJECT MUSE®

Selling Beauty

Martin, Morag

Published by Johns Hopkins University Press

Martin, Morag.

Selling Beauty: Cosmetics, Commerce, and French Society, 1750–1830.

Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009.

Project MUSE. doi:10.1353/book.3456.



➔ For additional information about this book

<https://muse.jhu.edu/book/3456>

[Access provided at 25 Dec 2022 02:18 GMT with no institutional affiliation]



This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License.

The Practices of Beauty

The Creation of a Consumer Market

Many historians assume that only the wealthy and the social elite wore the trappings of artifice in the eighteenth century.¹ General histories of cosmetics are principally built on anecdotes about the rich and famous. One oft-told story is about nineteen-year-old Marie Therese of Spain who came to the French court in 1745 to marry the dauphin. She reluctantly complied with the court rule to wear rouge only when she found out it would please the future king. Louis XV wore rouge around his eyes and may have wanted a well-rouged companion.² Napoleon was said to have told Josephine, “Go put on rouge, Madame, you look like a cadaver.”³ Rouge in these stories indicated assimilation into court culture, representing aristocratic privileges. Outsiders to the court often made opposing comments, finding the rituals of makeup excessive and ugly. After the educator Mme Stéphanie de Genlis was made-up for court, a courtier commented that “she has too much powder and too much rouge; she was a hundred times prettier yesterday.”⁴

Going beyond court habits allows us better understanding of day-to-day (or at least evening) use of an array of beauty practices. It is also a difficult task for a historian of material culture and consumption. The court was highly scrutinized and analyzed (albeit most often in catty tones), while eighteenth-century memoirs, novels, and letters do not spend much time on physical presentation. Portraits allow for a glimpse of the sitter or the artist’s preferred presentation of the face but are only available for the upper bourgeoisie and aristocrats. The practices of the middling and working classes, however, are to be found in the account books, death inventories, and advice manuals of the period. These sources give a sense of who wore cosmetics, what they purchased, and how they wore their makeup. By matching these archival sources with the commentary of observers and the portraits of the elite, we can start to put together a picture of cosmetic practices in the time before their banishment from visible public use in and around 1780. It becomes clear from this overview that there was a growing market for beauty products, but that these products did not conform to a single set of practices. Cosmetics use by the bourgeoisie,

by artisans, and by servants was worn neither strictly to emulate the elites nor to reinforce social lines. Rather, cosmetics created different aesthetic models of beauty from among which each individual buyer could choose, depending on the person's social setting, age, or financial circumstances.

A Short History of Makeup

Cosmetics were hardly new to the eighteenth century. The history of cosmetics is tied to the development of perfumes that first flourished in ancient Egypt and Greece but which mostly disappeared during the medieval period. In the twelfth century, perfumes made of both animal and flower essences were brought to Europe from Arabia. Perfumes were meant to purify, to cleanse, and to scent one's environment. They were applied to clothing and furnishings and not directly to the skin. These *eaux*, distillations of scents in alcohol or oil, were made with fruit essences and flowers. The scents of orange blossoms, jasmine, lavender, cloves, and the well-known rosemary *Eau de la Reine d'Hongrie* were popular.⁵ The elite burned incense perfumed with roses or other flowers in their houses. Perfumers also made breath sweeteners from such exotic animals and plants as ambergris (the bile of sperm whales), acacia wood (*catechou*), and cinnamon.⁶

As perfumery grew in the sixteenth century other products also developed. In 1533, Catherine de' Medici brought with her from Italy the practice of wearing rouge and face paint, which was quickly adopted by the French court. Throughout the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, cosmetics were used only sparingly, but with the reign of Louis XIV new practices arose. Louis XIV reinforced wearing wigs for his courtiers. Though hair powder had been used under Henri III, it wasn't until the early eighteenth century that elites applied white powder to color wigs and natural hair rather than as a degreaser. White-haired wigs' popularity (because they were the most expensive and rarest) led to this cheaper imitation. White and gray powders created uniformity and were less destructive than hair dye. By the early eighteenth century, court ladies had adopted this practice as well, though they sometimes wore colored powders to enhance their complexions.⁷ To contrast with white hair and to emphasize the wearer's nobility, face paint, rouge, and patches increased dramatically for both men and women under Louis XIV and continued in popularity under Louis XV.

Though cosmetics were first commercialized in Italy, by the eighteenth century, France had become the center of both the fashion and production of perfumes and cosmetics. French fashions spread to other European courts and elites. It was widely worn in the German courts and in Russia under Catherine the Great. Maria Theresa,

however, forbade the archduchesses and courtiers to wear makeup, implying that there were fashionable reasons to ignore her injunction.⁸ In Germany, more advice manuals on beauty were published than anywhere else in Europe: eighty-nine for the eighteenth century, with more than half coming in the last decades.⁹ In England, critics compared the restraint (or expectation of it) of their own women to the excesses of the French. As Lynn Festa shows, cosmetics were the ultimate form of distinction between nations. English commentators attacked the French use of makeup and felt that it made all French women look the same, taking the individual face and turning it into a symbol of the nation.¹⁰ The French, however, found English women's faces too pale: "Their faces look like their breasts, they are sallow due to whitening."¹¹ A 1798 poem equated frenchness with a playful coquette, whose beauty is enhanced by cosmetics, while foreigners and their countries have vices with "nothing covering their hideousness."¹²

The French woman defined by her paint and primping had many products to choose from. Advice manuals, advertisements, and articles in journals used the term *cosmétique* for both makeup and creams, which distinguished it from *parfumerie*, which included only products meant to add scent (to skin or to clothing). Cosmetics, in contrast, were products to clean or beautify the skin.¹³ Cosmetics entailed more specifically the art of "beautifying the body; of combating ugliness, of diminishing faults which can cause . . . repulsion; of hiding natural imperfections . . . ; and even of preventing infirmities."¹⁴ Within this wide definition of cosmetics, contemporaries included the subcategory *fard*, which consisted of "all compositions, be they of white face paint or rouge, which women and even a few men use to embellish their complexions, to imitate the colors of youth, or to repair them by artifice."¹⁵ Thus, cosmetics were essentially divided between those that embellished beauty through improvement, such as creams and lotions, and those that masked imperfections and created the illusion of color.

In this second category of *fard*, two types of makeup were most popular: *blanc* and *rouge*. The dominant aesthetic in eighteenth-century France was for women and men to show their respectability and class through the whiteness of their skin. Fashionable women took many precautions to preserve fair skin, such as using parasols and hats to keep the sun out. People not born with flawless features (and few were) covered their faces with heavy makeup, which became over time more respectable than naturally light skin. Elites applied white face paint in thick layers across the entire face and shoulders to erase signs of aging, disease, and freckles. This mask could be made with a variety of ingredients. Some recipes called for bismuth or vinegar, while others preferred the white chalk of lead (*céruse*).¹⁶ Since white lead was expen-

sive, most perfumers preferred alum (aluminium sulfate) instead. Alum could be turned into white powder and added to a number of oils for application.¹⁷

If face paint was the foundation of all elite toilettes, rouge was the finishing touch, meant to highlight the wearer's shiny white skin. Red cheeks were the ideal to which both fashionable men and women aspired, but because most had their faces already masked in white, they had to turn to artificial means. Recipes called for rouge to be made of minerals such as cinnabar (mercuric sulfide, called vermilion) or red lead. It could also be made from vegetable matter, such as safflowers (*catharme*), saffron, gum benzoin (wood resin), sandalwood, and brazilwood. One of the most expensive dyes was carmine that came from female cochineal insects found in Latin America. These dyes were originally combined with vinegar or lemon, precipitated on powder using alum, and then scented with flowers. This powder could be mixed with rose water or grease for easy application with a brush. Another type of rouge was *au crépon*, dyeing a cloth or paper with cochineal that could be moistened and rubbed on the face. Liquid vinegar rouges were also popular because they dyed the face for longer periods, were not greasy, and were considerably cheaper to make and buy. By the middle of the eighteenth century, perfumers started selling *rouge en pot* (pots of rouge) as a simpler and more portable means of applying makeup.¹⁸ The most common recipe for these types of products was a mixture of talcum powder, safflowers or saffron, lemon juice, and oil, a much more affordable product than rouge made with minerals.¹⁹ Lips, however, were not necessarily reddened; instead, they were treated with almond oil or goose grease to keep them smooth and shiny.²⁰ If color was desired, women dabbed their lips with distilled alcohol or vinegar. By midcentury, some recipe books and sellers proposed red pomades for the lips, some were even sold in stick form.²¹

In addition to rouge and blanc, women and some men wore *mouches*, black silk beauty spots, or patches, held on by glue to highlight the skin's whiteness. Elites wore patches in a variety of positions, each one associated with a form of flirtation. For example, a patch on the forehead was called the "assassin"; a patch on the cheek was called the "gallant," and one near the lips was called the "coquette."²² Numerous sizes and shapes suited almost any taste. One perfumer ordered an assortment of patches, varying from the size of a pea to the size of a half dollar.²³ To gain attention, court ladies organized their patches in designs, such as trees or birds on their cheeks and forehead. In England, patches took on political meaning; female supporters of Whigs and Tories sported patches on opposite sides of their faces.²⁴ To accentuate their whiteness, would-be or real aristocrats traced the veins of their necks and bosoms with blue coloring.²⁵

Other facial alterations were used to contain natural hairlines. Men used depilatory creams to lengthen their foreheads, which was especially necessary when they wore wigs that sat on the back of the head.²⁶ Women used the same creams to eradicate signs of facial hair and to thin their eyebrows.²⁷ In the late seventeenth century, both women and men plucked and painted their eyebrows, and some wore false ones made out of mouse fur.²⁸ Though these forms of grooming probably continued into the eighteenth century, they were never popular beyond the court. Instead women were told to rub their eyebrows with ripe elderberries or burnt cork to keep them black, and a few perfumers sold more complex eye makeup.²⁹ Women and men could dye their eyebrows with the same dyes used for their hair, using a small comb or brush. Since red hair was never in fashion and blond hair not in favor until Marie-Antoinette's reign, black or brown hair dyes were popular. The safer recipes included nuts and roots, but others contained white lead, litharge, quicklime, and salt. A sample of white hair dyed brown and blond, found in good condition at the archives of the Académie nationale de médecine, shows that deep auburns and strawberry blonds were possible using the chemistry of the time.³⁰ Even though some men and women chose to dye their hair, most members of the economic elite wore hair powder over either their natural hair or on a wig. As a by-product of starch, powder was also relatively affordable, though large quantities were needed to cover the hair. Powders came in a variety of qualities, from basic to fine, and were perfumed with orange blossom, jasmine, roses, and jonquils. Wigmakers or private individuals applied powder by blowing it onto the hair while covering the face with a mask.

If fards were products meant to cover up blemishes or to create false color, the purpose of other cosmetics was to enhance attractiveness by curing skin problems and lightening the skin. Creams, lotions, and essences were touted for their cleansing and whitening effects.³¹ *Pommades* referred to creams made from a grease base of either animal fat (such as pigs' hooves, butter, whale fat) or vegetable (such as olive oil or almond oil). Their main uses were to preserve hair (and wigs) and to embellish the face. Pommades were applied to the hair to soften and clean it but were also used for thickening and strengthening as well as helping the powder to adhere.³² Pommades for the face cleaned, polished, whitened, and moisturized. Specific types were touted to remove freckles, wrinkles, and smallpox scars.³³ Fashionable women desiring soft white hands also slept wearing gloves dipped in fat.

Another category of products was the *eaux* that were both scented waters and effective cosmetics. These distillations were complicated to make but had a variety of uses. Simple aromatic *eaux*, such as orange flower, jasmine, lavender, and rose, were used to perfume clothing and the home and to wash the mouth, skin, and hair.

These essences were also used to cure illnesses such as epilepsy, lethargy, and vapors.³⁴ Other recipes were aimed at whitening the skin and reducing wrinkles. Many of these concoctions were not even distillations but mixtures of common ingredients. Saltpeter and water, for example, were touted as an acne remedy. Men and women used egg yolks, lemon, and balsam of Peru (a sap derived from a Central American tree) to wash their skin. Urine, rose water, and wine supposedly eliminated redness.³⁵ A distillation of pigeon, milk, and almond oil was also a popular cure.³⁶

At the heart of the promises of white and unmarked skin was a fear of aging in a society where old age came in the thirties. To postpone or mask the rapid destruction of youth, cosmetics evoked miracles. A common recipe for combating wrinkles combined calves feet, river water, white bread, fresh butter, and ten fresh eggs.³⁷ To combat wrinkles, women wore headbands around their foreheads during the night. Perfumers also sold a popular *eau virginale* (made with vinegar), which promised to return women to their virginal state by contracting the vaginal muscles. There were also many mentions of *lait virginale* aimed solely at the hands and face.³⁸ Women and men also feared signs of illness. Cures for acne, pockmarks, and syphilis scars were common, as were remedies for freckles and sunburn.

Teeth, too, were to be sparkling white. Opiates, not all of which contained opium, were meant to keep the teeth attractive.³⁹ Recipe books touted *dentifrice* (toothpaste) made of coal and sugar or orange peel and honey. Aromatic tablets made of plants were recommended for bad breath, and scraping knives eliminated food from the tongue and gums. Perfumers sold powders meant to whiten the teeth and alcohol-based eaux to strengthen them.⁴⁰ When all else failed, eighteenth-century elite turned to false teeth made of ivory, human teeth, porcelain, or even hippopotamus teeth. These were not perfect solutions to the increasingly gaping smiles of the French elite because animal teeth smelled over time and porcelain turned black.

Although early seventeenth-century elite men and women washed their hair and bodies in water, by the end of the century, water was replaced by powder, grease, and perfume.⁴¹ Doctors believed that water weakened the body and should be avoided unless absolutely necessary. Fear of immersion was based on the theory that liquids penetrated the body and could potentially harm the internal organs. The elite only washed their face and hands regularly, dipping them every other day in aromatic waters or distilled alcohol, though some aristocrats did take full baths for sensual pleasure rather than for hygiene.⁴² To fend off unwanted smells, sachets of dried flowers were carried inside one's clothes and aromatic incense was burned in the house. The elite's attempts to mask body odors, however, would have had little effect on the highly noxious smells of the city. Since clean water was expensive, Paris's working-class citizens could not afford to use water for hygiene even if they had desired it.⁴³

Soap was available during the eighteenth century, but bar soap made of quicklime, soda ash, or potash served primarily as a laundry detergent. Cosmetic soap was thought to be “pernicious for the skin” because it dried it out. “Light *savonettes* made of pure cream of soap” were preferable. *Savonettes* differed from soap by the addition of perfumes and powder that dissolved in water to create a thick white paste with which to shave or to wash the face.⁴⁴ Even so, these products were not widely used until the nineteenth-century promotion of perfumed toilette soap, especially those imported from England. Instead of soaps, liquid almond paste was used to clean and to moisten the hands and face without water. Though better hygiene was a growing concern in the eighteenth century, its solutions were slow to spread, and water still remained suspect to many.

Most of the elite’s toiletry efforts took place away from washbasins and in an atmosphere filled with perfume, powder, and paint. The location of this ceremony evolved over the course of the eighteenth century, with the process becoming as important as the jars of rouge themselves. In the early part of the century, no special space was set aside in the homes of the rich for beautification. Furniture sets called *coiffeuse* were marketed to provide women with appropriate toilette surroundings. Elites created new rooms for these tables whose windows faced north to avoid unwanted sunlight.⁴⁵ Men were less likely to have their own rooms for this purpose but set up toiletry tables in their bedrooms. The very wealthy constructed special wig closets to store and powder their hairpieces.

A woman’s *coiffeuse* was decorated with many ornate boxes and bottles. Porcelain containers at the beginning of the eighteenth century helped elevate cosmetics to luxury goods. With the invention of *rouge en pot*, the wealthy could show off their taste and wealth by purchasing decorative containers. A porcelain jar from the Goncourt factory cost four gold louis, much more than the rouge stored in it.⁴⁶ Porcelain perfume bottles shaped like dogs, birds, or pretty girls, and boxes made of sweet-smelling orange peels (*bergamot*) filled with powder graced the tables of fashionable toilettes, making their contents seem more valuable. *Boîtes à mouches* were de rigueur for male and female outings, as well as discreet but expensive, compacts for rouge. Made of porcelain, enamel, or wood, the most expensive of these boxes were decorated with portraits or pastoral scenes.⁴⁷ A wealthy woman never left home without her traveling case, or *nécessaire*, which held her perfumes and toilettries. Marie-Antoinette commissioned a new *nécessaire* just before the flight to Varennes, prompting her maid to suspect that she was about to take an important trip.⁴⁸ Women carried *nécessaires de poche*, which housed one or two important bottles and brushes for emergency application, deep in the many pockets of their voluminous gowns.⁴⁹

This detailed description of what men and women wore on their faces and hair in the eighteenth century is derived primarily from the habits of the elite. Cosmetics were essential accessories to the pomp and ceremony of the court, integral to the maintenance of its power and prestige. These fashions then spread slowly to the urban and provincial elite, which included the wealthier ranks of the Third Estate as well as the nobility. The spread of cosmetic beauty manuals and the accessibility of products meant that a much larger population was capable of adopting some if not all these practices.

Homemade to Store Bought: The Function of Beauty Manuals

Most cosmetics before the eighteenth century were homemade creations, with recipes culled from published or oral sources. This tradition was crucial in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries when selling prefabricated perfumery goods was less common and not accessible to those living outside France's main cities. Recipes provided both men and women with the basic information to shape and to create their own toiletries. By the end of the seventeenth century, however, an increase in both perfumers and noncorporate manufacturers of cosmetics made the lengthy process of home creation less necessary, though still potentially entertaining and money saving. This development shifted production from the privacy of the home to the workshops of professionals. Recipes were no longer aimed at amateur distillers but at a budding group of literate artisans whose professional skills could be perfected and shaped. The public might still amuse themselves with home concoctions, but they now were primarily buyers.

Recipes for home remedies and beauty enhancements have a long history, dating back to the Greeks and Romans. Most of these recipes did not survive the medieval period; however, advice books became popular with the spread of cosmetics in the sixteenth century. Cosmetics recipes first appeared in *livres de secrets*, which promised readers effective love potions, stain removals, medicinal cures, and beautifying creams.⁵⁰ These early books were distinctly influenced by magic; one recipe for the darkening of the skin (an unusual desire) recommended the use of water from an alchemist's still.⁵¹ A typical cosmetics recipe demanded large quantities of costly ingredients and much patience. Only the aristocracy and royalty had the tools to create most of the cosmetics and perfumes described in these manuals. For instance, Louis XIII made his own perfumes, while Louis XIV enjoyed watching them being made.⁵²

As home distillation became popular and the use of perfume grew in the late seventeenth century, manuals started including more easily reproducible recipes. These books differed from earlier works because they depended on medical knowledge

rather than folklore. Their authors were often well-known physicians or elite perfumers. For instance, the king's doctor Lazare Meyssonnier, in *Introduction à la belle magie*, specified that he would provide memorable descriptions of all the important recipes for beauty.⁵³ Likely the most influential author at the end of the seventeenth century was Louis XIV's perfumer Simon Barbe who published *Le parfumeur français* in 1693 and *Le parfumeur royal* in 1699. Both works were reprinted during the eighteenth century and helped spread the popularity of home creations among the nobility.⁵⁴

This tradition of specialized beauty books continued into the eighteenth century. Esoteric recipes, however, all but disappeared, leaving prosaic lists of ingredients that most middle-class readers could assemble. Women were singled out as the primary audience for these home creations. Simple, straightforward recipes ensured they would not endanger themselves. One female author stated that she would "facilitate the creation and explain it as comprehensively as possible, to teach women to make the products that they need."⁵⁵ Authors advocated using edible ingredients, especially those found in the home. Bread was turned into skin creams and milk was mixed with eggs to create face whiteners.⁵⁶ Lemons made effective skin toners; vinegars functioned as astringents and rouges, while almonds, honey, and fruits were guaranteed skin softeners. Indeed, because food was commonly used to create remedies, some people criticized recipes for their wastefulness.⁵⁷ Emphasis on foodstuffs tied these published recipes to the oral tradition and to feminine pastimes. Most eighteenth-century recipes provided only lists of ingredients, with few details on how to make or to apply the product. Even in the early nineteenth century, most recipes were vague and differed widely in their proportions. The tradition of orally transmitted instructions meant that women could provide the missing steps of the process, depending only on the published work for reminders of ingredients or new formulations.⁵⁸

For each desired effect, a number of solutions were given, allowing the reader to choose between different techniques. For instance, face whitening could be achieved by various ingredients, including donkey's milk, egg whites, lemons, wheat, one's own urine, and wine.⁵⁹ Solutions for freckles, acne, dull skin, and wrinkles were even more common.⁶⁰ The lack of specific instructions allowed readers to tailor their concoctions to available ingredients and tools. The names given to each recipe reinforced practicality by providing descriptions of cures rather than fanciful monikers. For instance, one list of recipes included

5th virginal milk for the embellishment of the face

6th virginal milk for the whitening of the complexion

To make spots disappear from the face
To make redness disappear.⁶¹

Readers could easily find what they were looking for by subject and then choose between the different options. These simple recipes continued to be reprinted throughout the eighteenth century and into the nineteenth century.

Yet during the second half of the eighteenth century, no new books of recipes aimed solely at laypeople were published, and the tone of advice changed. Manuals aimed at the public primarily focused on teaching women how to apply products properly rather than how to make them, while recipe books transformed into commercial manuals to educate professional artisans. Writers no longer expected women to be capable of producing cosmetics in the home. Instructions now made a clear distinction between recipes for the public and those for artisans. Antoine Hornot, in his manual on distillation, listed only simpler recipes for decoctions rather than the more complex *eaux cosmétiques* to make them comprehensible to the general public.⁶² The division between homemade and professional products was also evident in the ingredients included: chemical ingredients were primarily the privilege of perfumers and distillers, while edible goods and plants were safer for amateurs. These authors, aware of the growing complications of chemistry and distillation, hoped to control and supervise attempts at home production. Hornot had “particularly paid attention to being clear and exact so . . . no individual can be without these ministrations, by practicing exactly what” he specified.⁶³ He believed that the practice of making cosmetics was not to be taken lightly and should be attempted only with proper guidance. This concern indicated a fundamental change in who could best benefit from recipes and advice. Previously authors tailored their works for lay readers, but Hornot’s work was dedicated to perfumers, who though “not the only ones it can serve as a guide” made up most of its expected audience. Buc’hoz’s *Toilette de Flore*, though it could teach womankind “the means of preserving their charms,” was specifically a “useful work for perfumers.”⁶⁴ Female readers were secondary as the market for cosmetics expanded.

During the eighteenth century, wearers of cosmetics were transformed from producers and controllers of their own concoctions to buyers of prefabricated goods. The division between simple homemade recipes and complex chemical potions reinforced the growing market for commercial cosmetics. The ease of purchasing ready-made goods was touted over the complications of private fabrication. Late eighteenth-century advice manuals distinguished between the artisans who could be better trained in their profession and the literate public who should purchase these goods in the proper market spaces. Though home production remained popular

throughout the nineteenth century and into the twentieth century, it was a minor aspect of the ever-expanding cosmetics market. This shift in emphasis redefined the sphere of beauty: the manufacturers of cosmetics were increasingly seen as professionals, while the wider public was defined as consumers of proto-luxury goods.

Those Who Wore It: Changing Patterns of Cosmetics Consumption

As the production of cosmetics shifted out of the home and into manufacturing spaces, the audience of buyers widened to include a diversity of social classes. Cosmetics became available to this larger public by the middle of the eighteenth century because of the progressive decline in the price of these goods and their increased availability throughout France. Aristocrats may have had private toilettes and porcelain jars, but cheap paper containers of rouge and powder were available in corner shops. Their buyers may not have entertained visitors in their private boudoirs, but they could purchase the same basic goods and adapt them to their lifestyles.

Historians studying probate inventories have found that mirrors were increasingly common in the homes of urban artisans and servants, suggesting their use in private practices of beautification. The ownership of brushes, dressing tables, and other accouterments of the toilette also signify a growing concern with personal appearance.⁶⁵ Though cosmetics were not listed in these inventories because of their perishable nature and low cost, plain white porcelain containers might indicate the ownership of cosmetics with cheaper and thus less ostentatious packaging. These traces of the toilette indicate that many of the lower orders followed a similar regime of ablutions than their betters.

Though the ownership of cosmetics cannot be definitively ascertained from probate inventories, the seized account books of bankrupt perfumers supply lists of their clientele. Thirty-one such books were included in this study, all from Paris. Only one book remains from the first half of the eighteenth century, with the majority of the rest coming from the 1770s and 1780s. César Robin's account book from 1737 to 1741 indicates he mostly sold to a female and aristocratic clientele. Among these women were duchesses, marquesses, the "Princesse de Bégué au Palais de Bourbon," and even the queen's servants. He strengthened his network of connections by carefully noting which clients recommended new patrons. These noblewomen bought large amounts of powder and creams, spending up to sixty livres a year on these items alone. Men were also on his client list. One especially spendthrift gentleman owed 315 livres for one year's worth of perfumes and powders.⁶⁶

The ledgers of perfumers in the 1770s contain a greater diversity of buyers,

though the lack of earlier sources does not allow any firm conclusions about a shift in clientele. The perfumer Du Haulant sold to both countesses and butchers, and Miraux had mercers, surgeons, grocers, and milkmaids on his client list.⁶⁷ Often perfumers did not even know the names of their clients, so they simply listed professions or descriptions. One was owed money by “a female servant, the husband of the market fruit-monger, the male cousin of the count, the fat female neighbor living on Verrou street, a lady with big breasts, the mother of the cask-maker, my charming female neighbor from the hôtel de Nevers, the miss with the tender eyes, a female neighbor with a sick child.”⁶⁸ Artisans and servants were among those who could thus buy cosmetics. This list illustrates clearly a diversity of cosmetic buying.

If we can ascertain how much and what types of cosmetics these individuals bought, we can also surmise with what frequency cosmetics were worn. The most typical perfumer's client bought large amounts of powder and pommades but not much else. They bought one or two pounds of powder at a time and a few sticks of pomade, which could be worn as hair grease or as a cream to soften and lighten the face. The most popular cosmetics were ultimately not for the face but for the upkeep of prominent wigs. In the available records, white face paint was hardly ever mentioned as an item for sale. Mouches were more common, but neither of these items of aristocratic artifice truly crossed over into the realm of popular cosmetics. Instead, most customers bought whitening creams or continued to make these products at home.

The quantities bought by consumers varied greatly. For example, M. Brevigny purchased forty-one livres worth of cosmetics and gloves over ten months. He bought perfumes, soaps, powder, creams, and even borrowed money from his perfumer to buy a turkey!⁶⁹ Over one month, Mlle and Mme Rocuchon bought fifteen livres of powder and little else.⁷⁰ Either this mother and daughter bought the rest of their cosmetics elsewhere, or they only wore a dignified amount of powder and no paint. In a much larger order, Mlle Lahaye bought fifty livres worth of powder, creams, gloves, rouge, patches, fake teeth, and perfume all in one day but failed to pay her bill on time. Other buyers returned multiple times in a month to buy small amounts of powder and creams, the two items that were consumed the fastest.⁷¹ The account books of perfumers indicate a diversity of practices and a clientele who probably shared their spending between various shops and outlets. Though it is difficult to generalize from these books, the impression is of a clientele who bought certain core goods regularly and periodically splurged for more expensive items.

Though these lists of clients do not tell us much about the day-to-day beauty practices of individuals, they do indicate whether men and women bought different products. One merchant sold both weaponry and hair powder to his male clien-

tele.⁷² The fard that appealed to both sexes, at least for a time, was rouge. A detailed inventory from 1768 shows both men and women buying rouge one pot at a time.⁷³ One provincial gentleman ordered “theater rouge,” while another complained that his shipment of face paint and rouge was delayed.⁷⁴ It is difficult, however, to judge whether these men were buying for their wives or for themselves. It would be safe to say that up until the 1780s, some men purchased rouge for their own use. Though few account books for the 1780–1800 period remain, perfumer Nager’s book shows a growing division between women’s and men’s purchases, with women purchasing most of the rouge and pomades and men continuing to buy perfumes and powder.⁷⁵ Rouge was only 1 percent to 7 percent of the total sales of official perfumers. Rouge undoubtedly made up a larger percentage of purchases since numerous specialized rouge sellers operated outside guild strictures.⁷⁶

Historians of consumerism and gender have argued that a growing differentiation among male and female fashion habits had occurred by the end of the century, anchored in the “cult of domesticity.” The discussion of fashion had become feminized and trivialized, as Jennifer Jones has shown convincingly, which implied rejection of cosmetics by men.⁷⁷ Though this is definitively the case in texts, it does not relate as directly to the purchases of consumers. A shift certainly occurred around 1780 that pushed men away from using visible makeup. Men continued to buy other toiletries, such as powder, creams, and perfumes in large quantities. By the early nineteenth century, as wigs became less popular, hair tonics and oils aimed primarily at men became the most prominent cosmetics on the market. The feminization of makeup still left room for men to participate in the practices of the toilette.

Even if men and women bought similar amounts, the cost of cosmetics circumscribed which classes could afford them. Prices varied greatly, depending both on quality and on reputation of the seller. Most perfumers offered wholesale discounts to other artisans, such as wigmakers and hairdressers. For instance, Méry sold his powder number six (of lesser quality) for one livre nineteen sols to wigmakers but to other clients for two livres two sols.⁷⁸ One ounce of good powder typically sold for eight sols to clients.⁷⁹ Two ounces of pommades sold for between two and five sols, though up to one livre for fancier scented ones.⁸⁰ However, if these creams were marketed as special cures, they were among the most expensive purchases. A pomade made with snails sold to eliminate freckles cost one livre five sols for a two-ounce bottle, and the famous *Pommade de Ninon*, meant to eliminate wrinkles, cost three livres.⁸¹ Rouge had the most varied prices of any product. A jar of rouge might be sold for one sol sixteen deniers to sixty livres, depending on its quality. Leaving aside the luxury rouge sold by Mme Martin, which sold for sixty to eighty livres,

most sellers sold their “superfine” rouge for between ten sols and three livres, depending on the packaging.⁸²

One commentator felt that these prices were “so cheap, that the smallest *grisettes* can lay out as much as a person of the highest birth.”⁸³ Yet an anecdote by Giacomo Casanova indicates what these prices really signified to a less-privileged cosmetics buyer. Having gone to visit a young girl whom he was helping financially (and found attractive), he watched her toilette in awe of her beauty. The spell was broken when the beauty’s maid chastised her for spending on “combs, powder and creams the three livres that she had been given.”⁸⁴ Three livres was not a large sum for the rich, but it represented half of a laborer’s weekly wages.⁸⁵ The wages of journeymen would have been considerably higher, ranging from ten to fifty livres a week, with most falling somewhere in-between.⁸⁶ Master artisans earned more, but independent businesspeople risked more as well. Women workers tended to earn less than men, though those running their own businesses could rise to the level of master artisans. Most of the working classes could not indulge in rouge and powder every day, but they could on special occasions. In small quantities, artisans and the wealthier working classes could buy most of these products. Many, like their noble counterparts, ran up substantial debts in the account books of perfumers.

Wages for servants and wage earners increased over the course of the eighteenth century, allowing a greater proportion to go to consumer goods.⁸⁷ Amid rising wages, however, was an even sharper increase in the cost of living.⁸⁸ Though this circumstance increased poverty among the rural peasantry, the Parisian working classes managed to survive and even purchase nonessential goods. Jan de Vries explains this contradiction by arguing that an “industrious revolution” occurred before the Industrial Revolution, starting in the mid-seventeenth century in the Netherlands and Britain.⁸⁹ More time was spent at work and less at leisure, allowing for a shift by the eighteenth century in the purchases of the working classes in France, from everyday objects to consumer goods such as fashionable clothing. Daniel Roche has found proof that even poorer workers exchanged “durable investments for consumer objects.” Though their economic situations did not necessarily improve, the working classes of Paris did not forgo buying consumer goods enjoyed by the wealthier around them. Instead, they gave up household necessities such as pots and pans to buy mirrors, dresses, and, as indicated in the account books of perfumers, cosmetics.⁹⁰

The rich did not often have to leave the privacy of their boudoirs to increase their beauty, enlisting the services of hairdressers, servants, and *modistes*. The middle and artisanal classes purchased these same services in shops specializing in the toilette.

Male customers frequented the stores of wigmakers who powdered wigs for a small fee. Louis-Sébastien Mercier described these shops as dirty, disgusting places, filled with putrid powder. The clients of these establishments were the neighborhood artisans who came on Sundays to have their wigs prepared for the evening's opera.⁹¹ Men of all classes also paid to have themselves shaved by barbers, though in Paris shaving became increasingly a private ritual.⁹² Nicolas-Edmé Restif de la Bretonne lamented that "I was the only man in Paris who still went to have himself shaved . . . in the wigmaker's store."⁹³ Women of the lower orders could have their hair done by hairdressers or they could do it themselves. The shops of perfumers also provided the tools for applying makeup and related practices, such as removing hair.

Shopping was increasingly a form of entertainment in the second half of the eighteenth century. For browsers and consumers, perfume stores, like those of other luxury trade, were part of the pleasure of public outings. The rue St Honoré and rue Richelieu attracted high-end buyers. Yet Restif de La Bretonne compared the rue St Honoré to a bazaar, where luxury and commerce mingled with prostitution and charlatanism.⁹⁴ Similarly, Mercier described the shopping in the Palais-Royal as both the most opulent and the most deceptive. The "eyes are fascinated by all the exterior decorations, which dupe the curious, who realize the trickery . . . only too late."⁹⁵ Though a pleasure ground for the elite, "debauched youths, thieves, *petits maîtres*, swindlers, prostitutes, and financiers" patronized the infamous *galeries de bois*, less permanent structures with cheaper rents.⁹⁶ Shopping was a perilous pastime that allowed for the intermingling of men and women in public, creating arenas for deception. Both male and female shoppers endangered the viability of the family: pretty shopgirls tempted men, while tempting products led women into financial excesses.⁹⁷ Casanova was more forgiving, describing the Palais-Royal as "a rather nice garden, . . . numerous men and women strolling" with "benches here and there where one sells new pamphlets, perfumed scents, tooth-picks, and knick-knacks."⁹⁸ Over time the threats to respectability diminished. Stores developed window displays, visiting areas, and lighting. Women may have shunned nighttime excursions, but during the daytime, the streets and fairs of Paris were filled with the intermingling of genders and ranks. In particular, the wives and daughters of artisans, often owners of their own businesses, had no fear of visiting neighboring stores for purchases.

Cosmetics could also be purchased in locales aimed at the working classes. Restif de la Bretonne described the atmosphere at the Foire Saint-Laurent as an ideal place for foisting unsaleable products onto unsuspecting consumers. There he saw "a few miserly, badly furnished stores; fortune-hunters laying out fashions like spiders arranging their webs."⁹⁹ The fair atmosphere allowed for more freedom in buy-

ing and thus more possibilities of lower prices and bargains. Street-corner sellers and itinerants also allowed the poorer urban classes to purchase products in their neighborhoods. Though there were no used cosmetics on the market (food was sold half-eaten, so why not rouge?), there were numerous venues that allowed working-class consumers to participate in the joy of purchasing beauty.

According to these same commentators, each social class had their own method of brightening their complexions. Court ladies wore rouge in uneven swaths across the face, from the corner of the eyes to the corner of the lips, to put sparkle in the gaze. Casanova argued that this intentionally artificial style was meant to invoke past dalliances and future escapades.¹⁰⁰ As a schoolboy, the Count of Fersen observed the Countess of Brionne putting on her makeup. After applying powder, she used a small knife to scrape off any that had landed on her face. Then one of her servants brought her a box containing six pots of rouge and one that seemed to contain something black. After she applied it, he realized it contained “the most beautiful red one could see.” She then added to this first layer from the other six pots, two at a time.¹⁰¹ The countess’s many hues indicate the expensive and artistic (or artificial) nature of the toilette for the elite. While visiting Paris, Henri Walpole stated that the princesses of the blood wore their rouge in the deepest red, “though all use it extravagantly.”¹⁰² In contrast, women of the bourgeoisie and the provincial nobility wore neat, circular dabs at the center of their cheeks while men sported theirs in small circles high on their cheekbones. The different hues of rouge were associated with specific social groups: the lighter pinks with the bourgeoisie and the darker reds with prostitutes and actresses.¹⁰³ Yet Mercier condemned the “ghastly mistresses of apprentice butchers” who wore rouge the color of blood and compared them to the “loose courtesans of the Palais Royal” who wore “rose colored” rouge.¹⁰⁴ Thus, in his description, it was the wives of artisans who copied the elites and the courtesans who wished to mimic the bourgeoisie. In this confusion, both emulation and distinction are present, but neither one seems to be definitive. While court rouge was set in tone and style, other forms and tones of rouge seem to have shifted meanings, depending on context, wearer, and, even more important, the commentator’s opinion.

Anecdotes, such as Mercier’s numerous snapshots of life in Paris, help us better understand what options were available for consumers of makeup. Like many available sources, however, they are the generalized witty observations of a few opinionated men. To visualize the wearing of rouge, face paint, patches, and powder, it is useful to turn to the iconography of the period. I have studied a variety of paintings and engravings, focusing especially on portraiture. There are inherent problems with using painting to reflect the use of cosmetics. First, paintings represent idealized versions of beauty and the individual tastes of the painter as much as the reality of daily

life. When a client complained that her complexion was painted inaccurately, Hyacinthe Rigaud responded, "It's astonishing—for my rouge comes from the same merchant as yours."¹⁰⁵ Even when the sitter had a say in how the painting looked, she (or he) was likely to pick a flattering pose and a mythologized version of herself. The popularity of allegorical portraits makes reading the fashion of the face even more difficult. Second, many paintings, especially after 1770, which show red cheeks and white skin, were attempting not to create the dissimulation of paint with paint but instead to reproduce the ideal of a natural beauty.

Genre paintings by François Boucher, Jean-Honoré Fragonard, and their followers depict young, beautiful women almost always with blushing cheeks and pale skin. Denis Diderot criticized Boucher for his "affectation, romantic gallantry, coquetry . . . rouged flesh tones, and debauchery."¹⁰⁶ Boucher's paintings, especially *Le déjeuner* (1739) and *La toilette* (1742), depict the full panoply of cosmetics available: hair powder, face paint, mouches, rouge, lip pomade, and black for the eyebrows. Fragonard tones down this excess in his paintings from the 1750s through the 1770s, emphasizing instead creamy skin and well-rouged cheeks. Yet even his shepherds and shepherdesses are highly made-up.¹⁰⁷ Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin's more restrained images depict servants and bourgeois mothers with rosy cheeks, though only the later have whitened skin.¹⁰⁸ These scenes reflect the beauty aesthetic of the period and, in many instances (especially the scenes of amorous tryst), imply a virginal blush rather than applied artifice.

Indicative of what elite women wore are portraits painted from 1750 to 1775. Jean-Marc Nattier's extremely flattering portraits of the royal family, high aristocracy, and *arrivistes* show women with bright, deep pink color applied in a wide circle across the cheek. For example, a 1749 portrait of Mme Marsollier, the social-climbing wife of a silk merchant, with her daughter, shows them at the toilette table in dishabille but fully made-up. As a rich woman with low social status, the sitter adopted the conventions of aristocratic makeup and pastimes (the extended toilette) to associate herself with and thus emulate her betters.¹⁰⁹ The style that she was emulating can be found in a number of portraits of Louis XV's daughters, depicted as enchanting and well-rouged virtuous members of the royal family.

The six hundred or so watercolor profile portraits of aristocrats, artists, and scientists by Louis Carrogis Carmontelle provide a wider snapshot of cosmetic practices. Carmontelle painted quickly while the sitters busied themselves with their everyday activities. Almost all of Carmontelle's women, no matter what age, rank, or profession, sport round, deep orange pink rouge, which takes up almost the entire cheek from ear to eye to mouth (figure 1). Only a few wear mouches, and the skin is pure white (unpainted on the page). Carmontelle's men are a more diverse



Figure 1. Carmontelle, *Madame la comtesse de Rochecouart* (1759), Réunion des musées nationaux/Art Resource, NY

group. Some wear no distinctive color, while others sport shades of pink along the cheekbone of a tanned face. Those in court dress are more likely to be depicted with rouge than those in less formal garb.¹¹⁰ Overall, paintings of the royal family, aristocracy and bourgeois elite by a variety of artists generally depict them as wearing round daubs of color, from orange to pink, with little bright red represented. These portraits emphasize the uniformity of paint among the elite, while downplaying the extreme color and stripes described by commentators.

A second group of portraits shows a different ideal of cosmetic beauty. Portraits of older aristocrats (outside of Carmontelle's oeuvre), nobility living outside the court spotlight, and the upper bourgeoisie depict much more subtle use of color, with no clear demarcation between the skin and the makeup. In Nattier's portraits of Marie Leszcynska, the Queen of France, and the Comtesse de Tessin in private

settings, both women sport light-colored rouge (or the symbol of natural color) spread out across their faces. These two older women, certain of their social positions, chose to be pictured in informal garb.¹¹¹ Similarly, Jean-Baptiste Greuze's 1749 portrait of Mme Léger de Sorbet depicts her with a generally flushed face rather than the distinct lines of makeup. Joseph-Siffred Duplessis' painting of Mme Lenoir, wife of a stocking merchant and mother of Alexandre Lenoir, the painter and founder of the museum of French monuments, shows a good *bourgeoise* with slightly rosy cheeks on pale but not whitened skin. Jacques Louis David's portrait of his cousin Mlle Buron (1769) portrays her with flushed pink cheeks on mottled, apricot-toned skin, not the bright white face of an aristocrat.¹¹² The elderly Mme Faventines, painted by Jean Valade, was a wealthy aristocrat, but her manner (doing needlework), dress, and face show her as a dignified matron who no longer painted her face.

These images show the diversity of fashions available for women outside the court. Young and old could wear paint many ways that were not categorized as described by commentators such as Mercier. The amount, color, and application of makeup depended as much on age and circumstance as on status. Court expectations dictated the use of makeup in a specific setting, but many aristocrats and up-and-coming *bourgeoises* chose not to depict themselves so obviously in their portraits. Rouge and face paint were the norm, but their application (on canvas) varied. Consumers who shopped the stores of the Palais Royale had choices: they could emulate their betters for an evening at the theater with thick dabs of rouge, be commemorated in painting with a rosy blush, and spend their private hours at home with no makeup on.

Conclusion

The growth of a population with a disposable income made possible the market of cheap luxury goods. Luxury goods could enter the homes of artisans and servants, allowing them to participate in fashion on a larger scale. This economic development represented a shift in the *mentalité* of the working classes. Luxury goods became necessities for those who had previously owned only a few essential items. Wearing cosmetics enacted in a visible way the new consumerism. Even though cosmetics were associated with the court and aristocracy, members of the lower nobility and middle class adopted rouge and face paint, with a new emphasis. The porcelain jars of nobles were rivaled by stoneware or paper cones of rouge in the homes of artisans. The swaths of thick rouge of courtiers lived alongside the round rosy cheeks of the urban matron, though neither style was limited to one specific group.

As Mercier stated, it was not so much the rouge that changed, but the price and thus the image each class had of it: “women of the court, who play a high stakes game, pay one louis for a small pot; women of quality, six francs; courtesans twelve francs; and the bourgeois, who wear it imperceptibly, do not haggle.”¹¹³ Rather than indicating a rampant emulation of elites, wearing makeup by a broader base of consumers helped delimit rank, occupation, age, and gender, while at the same time keeping these categories malleable. Because makeup could both delimit classes and provide hope of emulation, along with private self-fashioning, it was a cheap and available way for women and men to participate in the consumer revolution.